

Activating Joy and Hope in Critical Literacies Instruction: Responding Pedagogically to Youth Skepticism in a YPAR Project

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Abstract

In the face of persistent racial injustice, critical literacy approaches to instruction frequently involve investigating and altering unjust racialized power structures through critical action. However, what happens when youth have become understandably skeptical of action for change? This analysis uses healing frameworks to explore the critical literacies of Black and Latinx youth in a youth participatory action research project that took place in the early days of the Trump administration, as well as the pedagogies employed. The salience and persistence of racial injustice in national politics and the local school district operated against youth's reserves of hope and belief in change work, introducing tension into a project focused on transformation. As a pedagogical response, the project's two White coteachers facilitated new pathways for critical literacies that involved joy, care, and new audiences. This response focused on joy in critical work and prompted some, though notably not all, youth to reengage with critical action and articulate hope for justice in their local worlds.

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Even though schools and classrooms can be sites of racial injustice, they can also be places to investigate and transform injustice. Engaging critical literacies, which guide youth in reading the world (Freire & Macedo, 1987), is one approach for doing racial justice work in the classroom. Such critical literacy approaches often cultivate critical consciousness and then move to social action to support youth in actually transforming injustice (Comber, 2015; Kinloch, 2010; Morrell, 2008). Related critical approaches like youth participatory action research (YPAR; Cammarota & Fine, 2008; Mirra et al., 2016) and social justice curricula (Picower, 2012) also include components of social action.

But what happens to critical literacies and critical literacy pedagogy when youth have grown skeptical of social action's efficacy and value? This article analyzes how Black and Latinx students experienced this tension while engaging critical literacies in a YPAR project as well as how their two White coteachers responded pedagogically. Though this work was successful when measured against many of the tenets of YPAR and critical literacies instruction, such as centering youth's interests (Cammarota & Fine, 2008; Comber, 2001), participants resisted engaging in social action when they became jaded by the persistent racism in local school politics. This led us to reconsider the nature of our critical literacy classroom work and explore new avenues, such as activating joy and finding new audiences, with an ultimate goal of healing from racialized harm and restoring hope in action.

The Youth Equity Agents (YEAs) project took place early in the Trump administration (during the 2017–2018 school year) wherein always-present racism was amplified and especially salient. In the context of the YEA project—situated in a class at Community High School (CHS)—this meant that events like the cancellation of DACA and pushback against Colin Kaepernick's #takeaknee protests were especially visible examples of overt racism. At the state and local levels, there were also well-known Immigration and Customs Enforcement raids and a newly approved “show me your papers” law, which essentially authorized racial profiling in policing. The racism within these policies and events was palpable, and the hope for political change that the 2018 U.S. midterm elections arguably brought was not yet felt. At the school level, a particularly harmful event occurred just before the school year. The school district decided to turn CHS's historic campus over to another district school, a disproportionately White and wealthy magnet school whose enrollees were seeking a larger and more centrally located campus. Though CHS would get a new campus, this decision was made with little time or regard for youth input.

These events operated against the YEAs' reserves of hope and their belief in the change work that is often at the heart of critical literacies and YPAR pedagogies. This article will focus on the tensions this introduced as well as how teachers and youth responded pedagogically. I argue that critical work with youth should be approached

through a lens that carefully considers its costs alongside its healing potential and that our methods for critical literacy instruction can be expanded to include this.

Pedagogies for Healing

Ginwright's (2015) healing justice framework asserts that the material conditions of racial injustice result in accumulated harm for youth which manifests as a lack of hope. Restoring hope is a key aspect of healing in Ginwright's (2015) healing justice framework. This is facilitated by participation in "critical hope building civic activities" (p. 20) which have the power to fuel social action and change. In healing justice, hope is more than an individual or cognitive condition; it is collective and material, rooted in shared experiences of neighborhoods and schools. In the healing justice framework (Ginwright, 2015), collective hope can be built through sharing experiences with injustice, building a radical imagination for collectively dreaming about a just future, and facilitating critical action, which builds a sense of control over the future. Though the discursive move of building critical consciousness is important, a unique aspect of healing justice is that affective realms like care and joy are acknowledged as important to critical teaching.

In the YEAs Project, it was clear that we needed to address the school move, which was steeped in a long history of racially inequitable schooling in East City and low community engagement. However, the school move was seemingly fixed and youth were skeptical of both the impact and personal costs of change work. Thus, the very change work that might restore hope by altering material conditions was fraught. Following the lead of youth would mean respecting their hesitation about engagement, thereby leaving their lack of collective hope unchanged.

Critical Literacies and YPAR as Pedagogies for Healing

My conception of critical literacies is derived from Freire and Macedo's (1987) theory of critical literacies as reading the word and the world, alternatively known as investigating and altering power in the world. This analysis and the YPAR project draw from frameworks of critical literacies that focus on investigating material conditions of power and social action in addition to critical investigations of texts (Comber, 2015; Lewison et al., 2002; Morrell, 2008). As other researchers have asserted (Caraballo et al., 2017; Morrell, 2008), critical literacies are frequently engaged in YPAR, which shares a similar concern with investigation and action, specifically of social justice issues impacting youth (Cammarota & Fine, 2008; Mirra et al., 2016). While studies do not explicitly frame YPAR and critical literacies as healing work, this focus on altering conditions aligns with components of healing justice (Ginwright, 2015).

Research studies have documented the potential of youth investigating social issues of importance to them and engaging in social action (Akom et al., 2016; Kinloch,

2010; Mirra et al., 2016; Morrell, 2008). In studies such as Kinloch's (2010) *Harlem on Our Minds*, which is guided by both YPAR and critical literacies, youth investigated issues impacting them, namely race and gentrification in Harlem. Researching these issues through photography, reflection, and interviewing, youth engaged in transformative action through community forums, discussions with preservice teachers, and coauthoring sections of Kinloch's book. In Akom et al. (2016), youth researchers used their insider knowledge of Oakland to gather data on food insecurity via a mobile app and implement solutions like food stands in vacant lots. Youth researchers in UCLA's Youth Council of Research (Mirra et al., 2016; Morrell, 2008) investigated culturally relevant pedagogies and conditions of urban schools. They employed this knowledge in social action that altered educational research and policy by publishing their research on websites accessed by local teachers, in peer-reviewed journals, and at academic conferences and public forums. This resulted in documented changes in practices at their schools and state legislation in addition to contributing to educational scholarship. Across these studies, youth investigated issues that impacted them and potentially moved toward healing by improving the material conditions around them.

Studies also specifically address the inward transformations of youth through YPAR and critical literacies. Though not explicitly framed as healing, researchers have documented the potential for altering youth's visions of themselves as critically agentic (Cammarota, 2011; Comber, 2015; Morrell, 2008). Cammarota (2011) found that youth engaged in the Tucson Social Justice Education project shifted from hopelessness to hope and benefited by seeing themselves as agents capable of making change and through improved academic outcomes. Additionally, youth in place-based critical literacies advocated for changes to school and neighborhoods and saw themselves as belonging to and contributing to these places (Comber, 2015). Morrell (2008) also asserted that critical youth compositions in YPAR allowed youth to name oppression but also to move into envisioning themselves as change agents "working individually and collectively to challenge oppressive conditions" (p. 131). This is akin to the radical imagination that Ginwright (2015) identifies as a key element of hope and thus potentially healing.

Method

The YEA project was a YPAR project (Cammarota & Fine, 2008), explored using critical ethnographic methods (Carspecken, 1996). YPAR positions youth as researchers who can act upon social justice issues impacting their lives (Cammarota & Fine, 2008). Within this project, I facilitated youth's critical work with social issues as both a coteacher and partner. Though partnered work is central to YPAR, it is also common for university researchers to write "about the research with" for academic audiences (Mirra et al., 2016, p. 135). Thus, I also engaged in systematic research of the project to contribute to literacy research scholarship. It is from the researcher position that I explored the following questions:

1. How were six Black and Latinx youth impacted by the accumulation of racial injustice in their daily lives and school experiences?
2. How did two critical literacy teachers respond to this accumulated harm pedagogically?
3. What was the impact of their pedagogical response?

Participants

The YEAs were 25 youth who had self-selected an elective course at CHS during the 2017–2018 school year. This analysis involves six focal participants: Layla, DeMoe, Tiara, Wes, Samantha, and Teresa. Except for Teresa, who was an 11th grader, the participants were in the 12th grade and had attended CHS for all 4 years of high school. Layla, DeMoe, Wes, and Samantha identified as Black or African American; Teresa identified as Latina, and Tiara identified as Black or African American and Latina. The focal participants were selected for in-depth analysis of their experiences because they repeatedly expressed opinions about racism and schooling, including the school move, as well as social action. One limitation of using this criterion is that I may have excluded youth who did not feel impacted by racism or the school move; however, this analysis is intended to show that the accumulated harm of persistent racism is profound and marginalizing, not that it is equally experienced.

The YEA project was facilitated by two coteachers who were White women. Ms. Morrison, the official teacher of the class, was in her 10th year of teaching and facilitating youth activism at CHS. Following workshops on dismantling racism in the previous spring, some of the YEAs asked Ms. Morrison to refashion the elective course to focus on racial equity. The other teacher was me, a former English teacher at CHS, invited by Ms. Morrison to coteach and potentially research youth literacies. Given this, I was an insider-outsider in this space. Though I did not teach the YEAs specifically, I had taught their relatives and knew their school context well. This provided me with insight, such as understanding the critical literacies required of youth to navigate daily schooling there (Hendrix-Soto, 2021). Additionally, I regularly talked about my teaching practice at CHS, especially the ways that my former activist students had guided me in a complex project of both challenging deficit narratives of CHS known to outsiders while also seeking to repair material inequities we understood as insiders. Though I sustained engagement across a year, I did not know this group of students when I began the project, and my identity as a White middle-class woman meant that my experience differed from theirs in important ways. For instance, I came to understand the weight of racism and social action in response to it, over time and as an outsider, rather than through a shared experience.

Context

The YEA project took place at CHS, a small urban school in a growing city in the U.S. Southwest. CHS serves primarily Black and Latinx families and has been a source of

neighborhood pride in East City since the 1960s. It is a comprehensive high school where students engage in health science programs, environmental stewardship, and music programs in addition to core subjects. Though it thrives in many ways, it also faces challenges common to urban schools such as economic and racial segregation, with wealthy and White families (and disproportional district resources) concentrated in West City.

Though it is fiercely defended by its students and supporters, CHS is also subjected to deficit narratives and threats of closure. Within the past decade, CHS youth have successfully resisted closure through activism, such as marches, speeches, and letter writing, as well as interacting with media outlets to reframe the CHS narrative. Thus, a legacy of action has evolved; the YEAs were aware of this legacy and some considered themselves to have participated in the reframing of CHS by rallying to raise the test scores that are valued in our state. One aspect of this legacy was the perception that, following a failed attempt to characterize CHS, the district now understood the need for community input in decisions about CHS. However, the sudden school move decision betrayed that tentative trust.

The YEA project took place in a yearlong leadership elective course, which had historically focused on mentoring at nearby elementary schools. Based on youth interests, in 2017–2018, we also devoted time to critical investigations of systemic racism, particularly in the local school district. This included understanding the school move, as well as countering deficit narratives of CHS and its feeder schools. As seen in Table 1, common course activities included sharing critical concerns about social issues and current events, learning about systemic racism using digital media, acting upon local education through mentoring, and creating critical inquiry projects. I frequently taught mini-lessons developed in collaboration with Ms. Morrison around the inquiry aspect of the class but also took on a more extensive role in whole-class and one-on-one teaching later in the school year.

Data Sources

In addition to teaching, I collected data using critical ethnographic methods (Carspecken, 1996), wherein I sought to understand both the immediate context of the classroom and the power dynamics shaping it. To do this, I engaged in 131 hours of participant observation, attending most class meetings across the year, as well as mentoring sessions and extra-curricular events. Within the class meeting time, I alternated between taking notes and teaching. I expanded these field notes to include thick descriptions at the end of each day.

I also conducted 1-hour-long interviews with each of the focal participants. The responsive interviews (Rubin & Rubin, 2012) allowed for organic conversation, guided by a semi-structured protocol designed to investigate how youth understood racial equity issues, particularly in their educational worlds. The interviews were audio-recorded and later transcribed to preserve meaning and intonation. In quotations

Table 1. Common Course Activities in the Youth Equity Agent (YEA) Project.

Aspects of the Youth Equity Agent Project	Course Activities
Sharing critical concerns and becoming an inquiry community	• Community circles: Classes frequently began with open circle discussions where YEAs could voice concerns about critical issues and process current events such as mass shootings and the Community High School (CHS) move. • Social gatherings: YEAs, their coteachers, and other adults shared their concerns while bonding socially during picnics, field trips, and meals. • In-between spaces: Conversations about concerns took place between YEA peers and their teachers during project work time, while transitioning activities, and while driving to outside locations. • Critical inquiry projects: Youth developed critical inquiry projects based on their concerns, which they shared with the class in presentations at the end of the year.
Learning about systemic racism and resistance	• Digital media: We viewed and discussed short internet videos, documentaries, and movies about police brutality, ethnic studies bans, and racial profiling bills to investigate systemic racism. We also analyzed deficit narratives in media coverage of CHS. • Guest speakers: The YEAs engaged in a discussion about racism and youth change work, facilitated by a guest speaker. • Museum visit: The YEAs visited an exhibit on “Black and Brown Activism” in our city at a local African American history museum. • Racial climate survey: The YEAs designed a survey to understand the racial climate at CHS. (Permission to administer was not granted, but the YEAs, nonetheless, learned about ways to measure racial climate through surveys.)
Investigating and altering East City education	• Mentoring: The YEAs participated in weekly mentoring sessions with CHS’s feeder middle school and partnered with feeder elementary schools for special events like a holiday gift drive. • Photography activities: The YEAs took digital photos of campuses slated for closure, consolidation, or displacement to challenge narratives of disrepair and disuse. • Architecture process: The YEA class facilitated youth’s participation in the process for designing their new school. Youth shared emic knowledge of CHS and their dreams for its future.

excerpted herein, capitalized words indicate emphasis by the speaker. Phrases omitted for clarity are marked by the insertion of ellipses in brackets.

I also collected youth artifacts, such as photos and inquiry projects, as well as curricular materials. Additionally, to understand the political context surrounding the project, I collected artifacts of the school environment, local news stories about education, and my past reflections on teaching at CHS. The present analysis utilizes data connected to youth inquiry, particularly regarding racism and schooling, since this was the aspect of the project where youth engaged explicitly with persistent racism and that triggered a pedagogical response focused on healing.

Data Analysis

Analysis began from the entangled position of YPAR teacher and critical ethnographic researcher. I engaged in ongoing analysis to make pedagogical decisions. This provided me with preliminary understandings of the tensions of the project, such as youth skepticism toward social action, as well as an understanding of key pedagogical moves, since Ms. Morrison and I designed them intentionally.

Following the project, I initially coded field notes, interviews, and artifacts using codes derived from theories of critical literacy and YPAR, such as focusing on youth's interests (Cammarota & Fine, 2008; Morrell, 2008) or analyzing power in the local context (Freire & Macedo, 1987). However, from my entangled teacher-researcher role, some conversations and pedagogical moments stood out: discussion on youth and change, a museum visit, our uncertainty as teachers following these two events, a hallway photography activity, and youth presentations of inquiry projects. The persistent wonder of these data (MacLure, 2013) and worries about youth well-being led me to Ginwright's (2015) work on healing justice. In analytic memos (Charmaz, 2014), I used Ginwright's conceptualization of accumulated harm to analyze youth comments about change and returned to the larger data corpus to find additional examples where youth described the impact of persistent racial injustice. Ginwright's focus on affective dimensions of critical work as essential to healing was utilized to identify the nature of our pedagogical shift in response to youth skepticism. Finally, key tenets of healing justice, such as restoring hope through radical imagination and shared experiences, were used to understand how the pedagogical response addressed youth skepticism.

Findings

Accumulated Harm and Youth Skepticism

The YEAs' analysis of politics revealed that they experienced an accumulation of racial injustice in their daily lives and schooling. During the 2017–2018 school year, this increased skepticism around the impact of change work generally, specifically in dealing with the local school district.

In applying the healing justice framework to analyze community work in Oakland, Ginwright often described accumulated harm as the result of neighborhood conditions like frequent gun violence. The YEAs rarely spoke about violence of that nature, but when analyzing racism reflected in the current state and national contexts, the history of local school/community politics, and more recent events, they revealed that they indeed experienced accumulated harm.

Analyzing the national political context. During the project, youth expressed through words, actions, and body language that the national political context of this moment was overwhelming. YEA Layla best captured the psychic impact of Trump's election, when reflecting on the school day after the 2016 presidential election in an interview:

That day it was like dead silent. Most of the [newly immigrated] students didn't show up. Like a lot of the kids that you WOULD see, you didn't see them. And if they were here, they didn't say anything. Just kept their heads down and went to class.

Though we did not spend a great deal of time talking about presidential politics within the project, when youth did speak on this topic, it was in terms of feeling limited, such as the lack of options for removing Trump from office or being prohibited from participating in inauguration day protests in the previous year. Across our discussions, it was clear that the national context, which also included mass gun violence in schools, weighed heavily on the YEAs and contributed to a sense of hopelessness.

Racism in local politics. The impact of persistent racism was most clear when the YEAs analyzed the local political context including racism in schooling and housing. Throughout the project, youth questioned the efficacy of engaging in change work and invoked the language of social reproduction (Bourdieu, 1973) to suggest that short-term gains would not dramatically change the racial order of their school district or East City.

This skepticism was especially salient during a fall semester discussion on youth change, which had been facilitated by a classroom guest. One of the YEAs, DeMoe, resisted the guest's assertion that youth could impact the world, stating that "Nothing changes [...] it's the same shit, different day" and "it's bigger than us." DeMoe elaborated by analyzing the decision to move CHS, stating that there was little youth could have done to impact that decision. "We could have gone downtown [a proxy for protesting at district offices], but there wouldn't be any changes."

When the guest continued to challenge DeMoe's assertion that change work was futile, YEA Teresa jumped in with historical analysis of CHS and district politics. She referenced the well-known 2012–2013 student activism that resulted in the district canceling a contract to turn CHS over to a charter school:

If we do end up creating change, things happen over and over again. Look at that [the charter takeover activism]. They worked really hard and got that school out of here, stopped them from taking over, but then it happens again.

When Ms. Morrison questioned whether the two situations were the same, DeMoe and Teresa answered in unison “We’re being moved!” to affirm the similarity. Nearby, YEA Samantha elaborated and connected their comments to regentrification in East City: “If you think about it, it is the same thing, because what do you think is gonna come into this neighborhood when that new school comes here?” In her interview, she clarified that this was about White people displacing Black people in neighborhoods and community institutions like CHS; other YEAs engaged in similar analysis of regentrification, framing it as a persistent racial problem that they had little power to change.

Evidence that their voices would not be heard also contributed to youth’s skepticism about change work. The small number of youth who are aware of and able to attend the two summer community meetings firmly expressed that they did not want the move, yet the district moved forward with the plan.

When I asked about skepticism directly in interviews, youth referenced their lack of opportunity for true input. When asked why she and other youth were less interested in critical change work, Samantha answered swiftly, “Not being heard. Or [not] being heard and listened to.” When prompted for an example, she referred to an interaction with a school board member about the move: “He was listening, but he wasn’t LISTENING. We were like ‘here’s what we want. Here’s what we don’t want.’ And then for it to not be included into the plans, just like, well there’s no point in talking now.” When I asked Layla the same question, she also referenced a lack of real input regarding the school move:

I think the thing that kind of shut the [YEAs] down was because of the whole school moving thing. They were like, “All these people are coming to talk to us. No one’s really listening. Now we have something we don’t want.”

Youth became skeptical not just because they had something they did not want (the new campus) but also because of the marginalization they experienced along the way.

Reflecting on the larger historical context. Skepticism about change work was also visible as youth analyzed an exhibit on activism at an African American history museum in our city. Ms. Morrison and I imagined that this exhibit covering local activism of the 60s and 70s would inspire new ideas about change work, and we asked the YEAs to revisit the question that *they* posed during the fall discussion: If change is possible, how?

Inside the museum, youth viewed and commented on artifacts of activism in our city around issues such as inadequate housing, brutal policing, and inequitable access to education for Black and Latinx people. The YEAs articulated their analysis, concluding that most of the issues were ongoing rather than historical due to systemic and persistent racism in our city.

While analyzing a reproduction of a 1969 Black Panther Party newsletter, Layla and Teresa both observed that their demands for fair housing, education, and policing

had still not been met locally or generally. Later, in a section of the museum showcasing excellence at our city's former African American high school, I remarked on the irony of ongoing school segregation in our city. DeMoe responded with an analysis of his museum experience: "You know what I notice as you go through this? It's just the same stuff. Just sugar-coated more and more as you go through." When I asked him to elaborate, Teresa offered a specific example to the group: "How they are always trying to drive us out!" referring to White people repeatedly displacing Black and Latinx people in the history of the city. Though as coteachers we had hoped youth might find inspiration in past local activism, youth's analysis instead focused on the persistence of racism in their local environment despite activism.

Youth's comments in interviews and across these events represent an astute analysis drawn from emic knowledge of CHS and East City. They named the sources of their accumulated harm as they situated the school move inside of a racially oppressive history and persistent ongoing racism. This critical analysis of place is common in critical literacies instruction and YPAR (Comber, 2015; Kinloch, 2010), and it can lead to critical action. However, in this case, the YEA's analysis led them to question the efficacy of the critical action, signaling what Ginwright (2015) frames as an erosion of hope in response to the conditions of injustice. Since engaging consciousness to challenge injustice is a goal of YPAR and critical literacies instruction and the YEA project specifically, this was also a significant tension in the project.

Our Pedagogical Response to Youth Skepticism

Youth's understandable skepticism about change work was a call for us to reconsider our pedagogical approach. As White women who were not disadvantaged by racist politics in our city, it was not appropriate to simply counter their analysis, which was based on emic knowledge of East City as Black and Latinx people. While we did not wish for students to remain in this hopeless place, we needed to offer them material reasons for hope in this moment rather than simply insisting on the inherent value of critical action as we had in previous critical literacy work.

Ginwright (2015) asserted that to support youth healing, we must conceptually shift our understanding of what we need to know and who we need to be, to include affective realms like care and joy alongside the cognitive realm of engaging critical consciousness. For Ms. Morrison and me, this meant that our pedagogical response needed to account for what critical work cost the YEAs and reconsider the nature of critical change work. It no longer seemed appropriate to encourage youth to act as blunt instruments of change, aiming their hearts and bodies at the stubborn structure of the school district regarding the painful issue of the school move.

A new opportunity for engaging the school move soon arose. The CHS administration and the architecture firm building the new campus began to solicit community and youth involvement in a participatory design process. In this, we saw an opportunity to devote class time to this process and engage the YEA's emic knowledge of CHS to build an informed campus for future students. The course activities devoted to

Table 2. Opportunities to Engage With the Design of the New Community High School (CHS).

January	CHS hallway photo activity	YEAs used discussion and photography to investigate elements of the CHS they would like preserved or changed in the new design.
January	First community meeting	A participatory workshop with the architects of the new school. YEAs were unable to attend but the coteachers voiced YEAs’ ideas from the hallway activity.
January	Student workshop	CHS students, including the YEAs, provided input on school designs and the layout of the new CHS to architects.
March	Tour of recently built campuses	CHS students including five YEAs participated in a tour of recently built campuses alongside the lead designer of the new CHS to view and discuss design possibilities.
May	YEA critical inquiry project presentations to peers	YEAs presented self-selected inquiry projects to their peers. Three of the projects included a focus on the new CHS.

this are detailed in Table 2. Though we were not familiar with Ginwright’s framework at the time, these activities allowed the YEAs to do critical work with positive affective sensations, joyously engaging their digital literacies as an act of care for their school. Importantly, this also allowed youth to engage with a new audience, the architects seeking input from end users of the building, rather than the seemingly immovable school district power structure.

The hallway photography activity is a key example of a pedagogical response that engaged joy and care as a part of critical work. Just before the first community architecture meeting, we asked youth to discuss CHS and the new campus in small groups. “What did they love and wish to see preserved? What did they want to change at the new campus?” Following their discussions, we asked youth to move through CHS and document this using their smartphone cameras as a digital tool and upload them to a shared cloud.

During this activity, the YEAs discussed the upsides of CHS, such as the small community feel, as well as downsides, such as the lack of language courses and the inadequate bathroom facilities. Though much of the discussion focused on critiques rooted in their experiences, when they moved to the hallways to document, their photos primarily focused on positive aspects of CHS. The photos taken during this activity display the beauty of CHS (i.e., windows, courtyards, gardens), aspects that supported rich learning (i.e., small classes, studio spaces, a health science lab), and history embedded in the campus of CHS (i.e., student art, murals, monuments, class pictures). The photos they took through their unique and expert lenses as students who cared for CHS formed a counternarrative to the deficit stories that often circulated

about CHS (Hendrix-Soto, 2021). Additionally, during the activity, the YEAs were full of energy, talking and laughing while they sought out remarkable features of their everyday environment.

Though the YEAs were unable to attend the Saturday community workshop, Ms. Morrison and I attended and voiced the ideas shared during the hallway photography activity. Youth also had additional opportunities to express their thoughts directly to the architects during a student workshop that overlapped with the YEA class time. The YEAs and around 100 other CHS youth attended the workshop, which began with a presentation about innovations in school designs to promote collaborative learning and segued into opportunities for youth input: rating pictures of varied school designs, sketching ideal campus layouts, and a Q&A with architects. Engagement began slowly but quickly escalated when YEAs and other CHS students asserted their need for continuity on the new campus, such as keeping the current name and preserving artifacts from the current campus. They also expressed their desired improvements, such as better learning spaces with comfortable seating. Youth were the most excited about possibilities for the new CHS as they congregated around pictures of design elements such as solar panels, collaborative workspaces, and flexible classroom walls, placing green and red stickers on their likes and dislikes.

Based on the response to the workshop, we arranged for a tour of two recently built school campuses, including one built by the same architecture firm. Five of the YEAs attended this tour alongside other CHS students and provided direct input regarding the interior and exterior of the schools. Though we did not direct youth to do so, the YEAs also used their cameras to document these spaces, particularly new possibilities that would improve the lives and education of future CHS students, such as phone charging stations and the flexible classrooms architects had described in the workshop. Though all of the youth attending the tour would graduate well before the new CHS was built, they drew upon their knowledge of and care for CHS to articulate their visions to our tour group which included the lead designer of the new campus.

Hope for healing through critical inquiry. Students' inquiry projects represented another key example of altering our pedagogical response to adhere, albeit somewhat paradoxically, to youth's needs. Throughout our year together, a common refrain in the YEA's critical analysis of CHS was that they were not pushed hard enough academically. Though the YEAs' critical literacy work throughout the year would have been valid on its own, and many busy students would have preferred to not have another major commitment, we asked the YEAs to choose something critical they had learned that year and present it to our classroom community. These projects became another opportunity for youth to reengage with critical work in a manner that suited their interests and well-being.

Four of the focal participants' projects focused directly on schools, with three projects involving the new CHS campus. Wes's project on the relationship between athletics and academics addressed athletic facilities at the new campus briefly. Layla's



Figure 1. Layla's photo of natural light and courtyards.

and Tiara's projects focused directly on challenging injustice through the future CHS design.

For Layla's presentation, she narrated a slideshow of her photos from the tour of the newly built schools. Figure 1 is a photo taken by Layla with her phone. Her commentary guided her peers' attention to positive features similar to CHS's current campus, such as natural light and courtyards (both seen in Figure 1); aspects of the new construction that would address known problems at CHS, such as music practice spaces; and new ideas introduced by the tour, such as music instead of bells and flexible science classrooms. Layla also showed her peers several pictures she took of the bathrooms in one of the new schools, causing a small flurry of conversation among the YEAs, since inadequate bathroom facilities were a common complaint of CHS students. Layla wrapped up the presentation by telling her peers, "Now, that I have been there, I see lots of potential for what they can do for the new CHS."

Tiara's project was also inspired by our school tours but focused specifically on school entrances and security. Our tour had occurred a few weeks after the mass shooting at Marjorie Stoneman Douglas High School in Parkland, FL, so the security measures at schools stood out to youth. Tiara, a yearbook editor who carried a

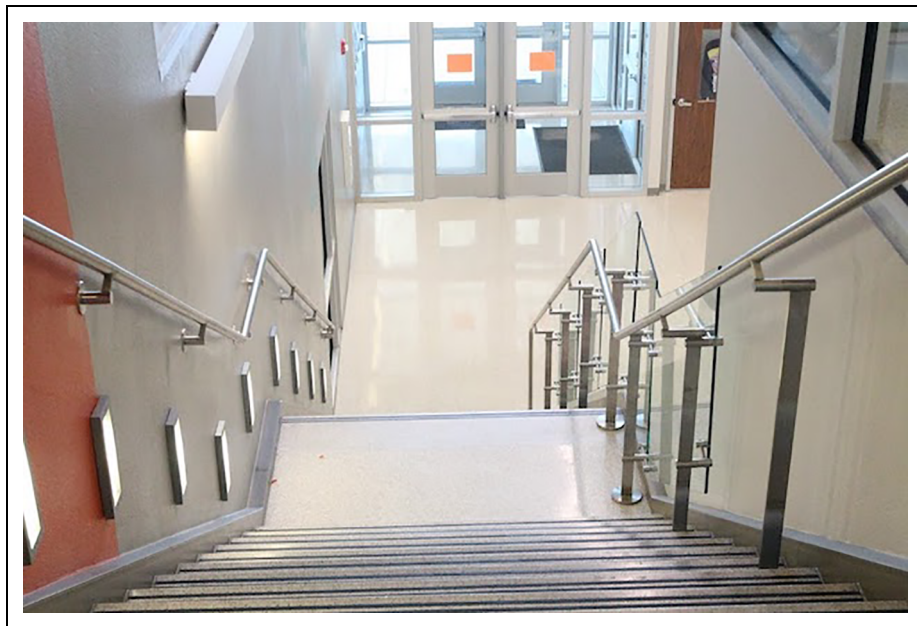


Figure 2. Tiara's photo of a secure school entrance.

professional camera, used pictures she had taken of the entrances (see Figure 2) in a presentation titled "Security and Improving the School." Tiara talked over the slides making the case that the new CHS should have double secured doors wherein visitors would be buzzed into an office, which was impossible in the current CHS building.

Before and after her presentation, Tiara expressed that she was excited about the project and the possibility to impact change. In the days leading up to the project, Tiara sought me out to say, "I am actually kind of excited about doing the final. This actually could change things. Teachers could see it and be motivated by it." In an interview a few days after the presentation, Tiara connected this to her experience touring newer schools.

The thing that really inspired me the most was the fact that we're getting a new school. [...] The security stood out to me because of all the school shootings going on. And I know there are a lot, like a lot of people are scared. [...] At those other schools, I was like why don't we have this, the security system that I saw?

Tiara also envisioned future work on this topic, invoking a sense of agency over an issue of importance to her: "I feel like I want to do a documentary. Just going around asking students how they feel about the security system and people just walking around."

For Layla and Tiara, the tours of the new school were hope building activities, wherein they could envision a building that reflected their input, CHS's past, and improvements the CHS community deserved. This did not minimize the loss represented by the displacement, but provided an avenue for hope, which they felt compelled to share with peers via their projects.

The limitations of pedagogies for healing. Though many of the YEAs did take up the pedagogical invitation to reengage with the school move in critical hope building activities, DeMoe's experience points to an important limitation. DeMoe had strong feelings about education at CHS, expressing care and pride through his involvement at CHS and his words. It was a family tradition to attend CHS: "Everybody in my family went to the school. My mom, aunties, cousins. So, I decided to come here."

DeMoe also perceived that the CHS class of 2018 (his class) had contributed to CHS's successful resistance by raising test scores and attendance rates to comply with state accountability measures that had previously rendered the school vulnerable. For DeMoe, this meant that the move was not just a change in location, but the loss of a school in which he and his family had personally invested.

It's basically like we rebuilt it. We have rebuilt a school just to give it up. [...] Now that we're back on our stuff, like back on point with our test scores, like attendance-wise, it's crazy now just hearing that we're actually moving the school [...] That's like saying you get an old car, you fix it to where you want it to be, just to sell it.

DeMoe's engagement with the design of the new CHS was limited. He visibly and audibly enjoyed taking photographs of unique features of CHS such as the art installations done by past students, but he asked to leave the architecture workshop entirely, clearly angry, and did not participate in the school tours. Though DeMoe's strong feelings about CHS and his artistic talent could have compelled him to contribute to the new design, he did not see the process as worthy of his time or labor. Following the architecture workshop, Ms. Morrison did reach out to campus administration, requesting that they attend to the pain DeMoe and others were displaying, as representatives of the power structure causing harm, but there was no response. For his final project, DeMoe produced an autoethnographic film about his experiences as a young Black male that undoubtedly held the potential to create ripples in the world, yet he did not change his stance about the utility of change work for altering systemic racism, especially in his local context.

Though DeMoe was somewhat of an outlier even among other skeptical youth, his experience is an important one. We had hoped that our turn toward productive activities with a new audience actively seeking youth knowledge would be a partial antidote to the accumulated (and accumulating) harms the YEAs were experiencing, but DeMoe did not engage. We did not ask about his reasons explicitly, but it would be understandable if DeMoe did not want to engage in critical literacies infused

with joy while the harm caused by the school district, and his personal pain, went unaddressed. At the same time, he no longer believed in the value of critical actions that might lead to some form of redress, such as protesting at the downtown school board meetings. This would have left DeMoe in a bind, where none of the seemingly available options were worthwhile.

Discussion

The accumulated harm resulting from the persistence of racism in the YEA's lives made them skeptical about the power of critical action. This was not a matter of needing critical pedagogies to introduce the concept of critical action; as youth living in East City and attending CHS, they were familiar with resistance to systemic racism in forms such as the protests, letter writing, and public speaking that had saved CHS from a charter takeover in the recent past. The experience of having their voices ignored, and the magnet school's need for a larger campus prioritized, led them to question whether any actions could challenge the persistent racism in this context or any other. Throughout the project, youth sought answers by employing critical literacies to analyze resistance to systemic racism in numerous contexts: local school and housing politics, local history, and our state and national politics. Across all of these sources, they concluded that systemic racism persists even in the presence of critical action that *should* alter it. This led to what Ginwright (2015) frames as an erosion of hope because they could not see it in material conditions around them.

The coteachers responded pedagogically by offering potential, critical, hope-building activities (Ginwright, 2015) in the form of the photography activity, architecture workshops, school tours, and inquiry presentations. These were opportunities for youth to use the tools of investigation and transformation that are at the heart of healing justice pedagogies to alter one hurtful issue from the accumulated harm of persistent racial injustice. Youth reauthored deficit narratives and countered the school district's dismissal of their knowledge through these activities. The already critically conscious YEAs added joy and care to their repertoires for action through their work in the project.

Ginwright (2015) asserted, however, that healing justice should transform the institutions and relationships that are causing harm; given that the school district was the power structure frequently causing harm, the YEA project did not drastically change that institution or CHS's relationships to it. However, though it is beyond the scope of this project and my positionality to claim healing for any of the YEAs, the willingness of some of the youth to reengage with the topic of the new school points to the potential of critical literacy pedagogies that activate joy to restore hope, an essential element of healing. Whereas the early conversations of the YEAs reflected more of what Ginwright (2015) frames as suffering or, at best, surviving seemingly immutable conditions of injustice, the words and actions of Layla and Tiara reflected promising conditions, wherein collective hope was on the rise. In their presentations, they drew upon shared experience to offer this radical imagination (Ginwright, 2015)

of justice at the new CHS for their peers' consideration, offering a potentially restored relationship to hope. However, though we found a pedagogical response that seemed to both respect and push against the skepticism of some youth, DeMoe's response points to the limits of pedagogy alone for healing the harms of persistent racism.

Implications

Though we held out hope for hope and sought new ways of facilitating it, the questions the YEAs raised about youth change work deserve to be taken seriously by educators and researchers. Both YPAR and critical literacies are decades-long traditions at this point, yet youth pointed to good evidence that the critical action at the core of these traditions did not produce the change they wished to see. The YEA's questions call us to attend to specific dilemmas of critical work: How do we know when critical engagements cost too much, particularly for Black and Latinx youth? How can we expand critical work to focus not only on critique but to focus on joy, healing, and futurity? Critical work often and justifiably centers the needs of Black and Latinx youth, but how can it also share the labor of challenging racism with dominant youth and adults in power? This is an especially important consideration for me as a White educator without experience confronting racism targeted at me. Using my voice or body to speak against these forces does not represent the same level of risk or potential for disappointment, so I need to carefully consider the costs, means, and responsibilities of critical action within my pedagogies, and finally, how can our critical work move the needle on racial justice and eliminate the material conditions that harm youth like the YEAs?

Postscript

At the time of this writing, construction of the new CHS is almost complete. The space is beautifully coauthored by many people, but the YEA's specific wishes are present: natural light, green spaces, multiple athletic facilities, and a secure entrance. Throughout a decade resisting attempts to close or sell CHS, no one imagined a new \$80 million campus as an outcome. While a building alone cannot ensure equitable education for Black and Latinx students in East City, and nothing can excuse the pain caused by the district's failure to engage youth in a decision that impacted them, the building's four-story presence on a high East City hill overlooking downtown, is a testament to the YEA's and other CHS youth's refusal to be erased.

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